

**Report to his most Saintly Excellency,
Justin Dorhawld,
Prelate of Saint Severinius, Dominus Maximus of the Ecclesiarchy of St. Severinius**

November 24, 1749

I, Eremauld Von Gruenstein, humble servant of the Saints, Invested of St. Severinius, Honourable Brother of the Order of the Staff, Emissary and Speaker of the Ecclesiarchy in the Republic of Waldheim, do submit this report to Prelate Dorhawld, on the eve of the Pentanum, for his consideration. It is my understanding that no political reports have found their way back to the Ecclesiarchy in recent years, and with the sitting of the Conclave next year, it is my duty to bring the most Worshipful Prelate what news it has been my solemn oath to gather.

I submit to you a lengthy report, and beseech you to forgive me if I prattle on about a good many things that your vast intellect already commands, but the coming of the Pentanum requires that I make the most diligent effort possible to convey every detail of the political doings of the Republic of Waldheim (hereafter referred to as the 'Republic'), illuminating every detail.

My report shall be ordered into several chapters, for your consideration. These shall include the following;

1. Structure of the Republic and Notable Figures
2. Political Division of the Republic and her Workings
3. Nobility of the Republic
4. The Workings of the City of Waldheim, including
 - A. Political Structure of the City
 - B. Political Division of the City and it's Workings
 - C. Commerce and Trade in the City

1. Structure of the Republic and Notable Figures

As is well known, Waldheim has been a Republic since October 1, 1346 when the Order of Bellwether took command of the City. Though it has remained a Republic of sorts ever since that time, her governance has undergone many changes. Herein is a report of her current organization.

At the top of the Republic is the Pentarchy; a group of five Consuls who are appointed by the Senate. A new Consul is appointed every year, for a five year term. Not all serve the full term; some die beforehand, some are deposed by the Senate, and some retire honourably. If a Consul serves his fifth year, he is known as Proconsul, and he has some extra authority; the Senate may not depose him in his fifth year, and he may veto Senate appointments to the Pentarchy. In the past, ambitious Proconsuls have attempted to seize more power from the Senate, which has lead to very few Consuls arriving at this point in their political career. The current Proconsul is an exception; Proconsul William Falconer,

Count of Falconer, Bishop of St. Sebald's Waldheim, is a strong man who has managed to achieve the rank of Proconsul through the merits of Blood, Wit and Faith. He is strong in all regards, and he is presently an effective balancing force for the Senate.

The other four Consuls include the following figures;

Consul Lucius Ulmar. (Count Ulmar) This man is in his first year of Consulship. He is another member of the Old Blood, a Noble of no small standing, and a Brother of the Pilgrims of Vander. That he was admitted into the Pentarchy, past the veto power of Proconsul Falconer indicates that these two powerful families are again allies. This suggests a certain degree of unification and coordination on the part of the Families of the Old Blood, likely in response to the coming of the Pentanum. Their timing is impeccable.

Consul Drake Whiddington. (Earl of St. Troy-on-the-Moor) Consul Whiddington, in his second year of Consulship, is a lowly-placed noble from an obscure county, but he is a crafty politician, with years of service in the Senate, the Council of Aldermen and the House of Lords. He controls a good number of the Livery Companies (the City of Waldheim equivalent of trade guilds) of the City through political guile alone, and has been actively increasing the size of the Republican Army for the last year.

Consul Benjamin Whitehall. (Master of the Company of Haberdashers) Consul Whitehall, in his third year of Consulship, is a Man of the City. He is the head of his Livery Company, has served several terms in the House of Commons, served in the Council of Aldermen, has been mayor twice, and holds a great deal of sway with the Freemen of the City, and the other Livery Companies. Though in our country we would look down on such a trade as a 'haberdasher', this trade guild is quite powerful in the City, and it is mostly through his seniority in this guild that he has made his achievements. Whitehall is also a Faithful follower of St. Severinius, which also explains his success. We shall find him a useful ally when the Conclave is assembled.

Consul Jack Spinner. (Master of the Company of Silversmiths) Consul Spinner is the consummate self-made-man-with-humble-origins. He managed to claw his way into power through the careful manipulation of Company politics, achieving the rank of Master at the young age of 44. Though the Patron of the Company has always been St. Dunstan, Spinner is a Faithful follower of Ulric. The faith of Ulric in the Republic, as you are likely aware, is associated more with the 'New Finance' than the traditional portfolio that we are familiar with in our country. Spinner was instrumental in the creation of the Bank of Waldheim, and it is rumoured that he is privately underwriting a number of financial projects, the details of which, I am ashamed to own, baffle me. Spinner was granted the title of Baron three years ago by the King, but he was stripped of this title earlier in the year for his participation in one of his fiscal plots. He will likely thrive without the title, though; Spinner is rumoured to be the richest man in the Rebulic, and perhaps all of Avilund.

Beneath the Pentarchy is the Senate. The present Senate is made up of 99 men from all over the Republic. The senate is composed of 33 members of the Nobility, 33 members of the Clergy, and 33 members from the Livery Companies. Each of these Estates is responsible for the election of its Senators, though only in the Livery Companies are there any real campaigns of election; the Nobility decide amongst themselves in their House of Lords, and the Clergy decide in Senatorial Synods, where our Faith holds great influence. Indeed, there has never been a Senate that did not include the Archbishop of St. Severinius (Waldheim). The Senatorial elections amongst the Companies are lively affairs that are composed of equal measures of revelry and acrimony. That the Livery Companies of the City hold 33 seats in the Senate is a testimony to the importance of the City in Republic politics.

The Senate is responsible for most of the decision-making in the Republic. They make new laws, decide on taxes, conduct foreign affairs, and so on. The Pentarchy reviews all decisions made by the Senate, and then vote amongst themselves on the measure, approving it, or declining it.

Beneath the Senate is the Common Council. This is a body of dizzying proportions; their last sitting (in March) saw 645 members in Council, and it lasted for several weeks. The Common Council is made up of one representative from each Parish in the Republic. Members of the Common Council hold a myriad of titles; they include Reeves, Deacons, Mayors, Priests, Aldermen, and so on. Members of the Common Council discuss the issues that are important to their Parish, and decide on issues which must be brought forth to the Senate. The Common Council has no legislative powers, but does act as the second highest court in the Republic, hearing those cases which have appealed their way up the complex legal ladder of the Republic. Deciding these cases is the only legal power they have, but this has proven potent enough with the Republic's reverence for what they call 'Case Law'.

After spending several years here, I have come to the conclusion that the Secular nature of the Republic, which I was told to expect before I came, does not actually exist. With a third of the Senate being reserved for significant members of the Clergy of the Saintly Faiths, and the remainder being mostly Saintly men themselves, there is adequate representation of Saintly matters in the Senate. The Common Council is composed of men from each Parish, the Parishes being by nature a Saintly Division of the Republic, and more than half of the Council are therefore Clergy themselves.

The Following of Ulric and Severinius in the Republic, and in the City in particular, is strong and ubiquitous. It seems logical that a highly-Secularized polity with a complicated organization and workings would rely heavily upon the Wisdom of St. Sever, but I was more than surprised to see the extent to which Sever does in fact influence Waldheim. The Following of Ulric is easily the second-most influential Faith in Waldheim, though this is a new development, I have learned. In the last several decades, with the proliferation of the 'New Finance', this Faith has grown in power, influence and wealth, and will continue to do so for some time.

St. Ignatius is a distant third in the ranking of influential Saints in the Republic, despite the Ecclesiarchy of St. Ignatius being Waldheim's chief ally. The population of the Republic, in the City especially, is largely literate, so it stands that Ignatius would have some influence here, but I was surprised at the predominance of Sever and Ulric.

The following of St. Cardigan is also pervasive in the Republic, though Cardigan enjoys no writ from the Scion. Cardigan is a regional Saint, and the patron of all the Saintly people of the Republic. There are shrines to Cardigan everywhere, and all civil proceedings are commended to Cardigan's guidance. Despite this, the Cult of St. Cardigan does not have much wealth or influence, and is politically inert on the international level.

2. Political Division of the Republic and Her Workings

The Republic is composed of 21 Counties and the City. The Counties and the City are composed of a large number of Parishes. The borders of the Counties are as arbitrary as they are ancient and immutable; they have not changed for over 1000 years. Parish boundaries are likewise firm, though Parish names have changed a little over the centuries, reflecting the waxing and waning of specific Saints.

Each County is headed by a Senator. Though this position is nominally a democratically elected one, the reality is that the Count of any given County is always installed as Senator. The nobility will be dealt with in greater detail, below. The Count is answerable only to the Senate and the Pentarchy, both of which tend to keep out of the affairs of County politics. Counts are responsible for the collection of taxes for the Republic, which is carried out through their system of Peerage, again, detailed below.

Each County is responsible for the maintenance of one Royal Regiment. A Royal Regiment is composed of at least 1000 troops, headed by an Earl. Some of the larger Counties maintain more Royal Regiments, some of which number 2500 troops. Though the presence of the Royal Regiments of The City is strongly felt, I am told that in the Counties, especially the more remote and rural ones, that the regiments are not standing; the soldiers work as farmers and labourers, and there are scarcely any men in uniform to be found.

Each County has a Capitol, which is usually an ancient castle of a noble family and surrounding village or town. The Capitols are required to keep several municipal offices staffed and operational, including a County Court, a Registrar, a Royal Regiment Staff Headquarters, an Exchequer, a Diocese Bench, a Hospital and a Royal Seminary.

The County Court is the third-highest court in the Republic. Here, appeals from the lower courts of the Parishes are heard, as well as trials for Treason and Heresy. This Court is attended by a Magistrate, who is appointed by the Count. County Courts

typically sit every 3 months, though some as often as every week in the larger Counties.

The Registrar is an office that is akin to a census-taker and notary combined. This office is responsible for the compiling of all demographic information for the County, and since 1655 they have kept the best census records in Avilund that I am aware of. The Registrar also files legal documents and agreements. The position of Registrar is also appointed by the Count.

Royal Regiment Staff Headquarters offices vary greatly County to County, I am told. In some of the bywater Counties, there might be a single old Sergeant or Lieutenant dozing at a desk. In others, there might be a busy garrison, and dozens of staff conducting their business. These places take care of all the usual military business one would expect. This office is headed by an Earl from the Parishes, who is chosen by the Duke, ideally for his military prowess, but not always.

The Office of the Exchequer is a new office that has developed with the New Finance. This office is responsible for keeping track of County taxes and expenditures, but it also acts as a bank; an officer here will verify and honour or issue paper currency and trade notes of all kinds. The Exchequer himself is appointed by the Count, but must be trained in the City and meet the approval of the Bank of Waldheim before filling his office.

The Diocese Bench is an office that anyone from our country would be quite unfamiliar with. The *Regula Dioceseae*, as it was laid down by St. Sever, has not been followed by the Republic for centuries. There are really no Dioceses in the Counties; rather, a County is recognized as its own Diocese, and the Bench is responsible for all non-secular issues in the County. This office mediates Issues of Faith that cannot be handled at the Parish level. This office is headed by a Priest of any Sainthly Faith, usually the Canon most-represented in the population of that County. The Bench also serves as the second-highest ecclesiastical court in the Republic (the Parish Bench being the lower, and the Court of the Blue Palace being the higher).

Hospitals in the County Capitols are of varying qualities. In some of the larger, and more prosperous Counties (such as Saxbury), the Hospitals are large buildings with a teaching staff of several surgeons and the most modern instruments. In some smaller Counties, it is not recommended that the visitor take ill. Every hospital is required to have a Surgeon, but these are of varying quality and qualifications. Hospitals are headed by a Lancet Master, who is often a Surgeon with noble blood.

Royal Seminaries are schools for the citizens of the County where a decent education may be acquired. I have had the chance to visit the Royal Seminary of Saxbury, and I report that it is a first-rate institution. The Royal Seminaries are staffed and headed predominantly by the Clergy of St. Ignatius, as one would well expect, but they are required to keep to a secular curriculum. Some have large libraries and extensive

labs, and dozens of professors. The Royal Seminaries are headed by a Dean, who is appointed by the Count.

The common defense of the Republic is an organized matter which has proven effective in the past, but which is unchallenged presently. As mentioned, each County provides at least one Royal Regiment, and the City provides 7. There are 41 Royal Regiments in total, which number from 1000-2500 foot. Three of the Royal Regiments are cavalry, each with 500 horse. The Republic thus maintains the second-largest standing army in Avilund, though it has not seen real action in the last 150 years, and lacks experienced veterans.

The parish is the basic unit of political organization in the Republic. There are over 700 of them, with more than 50 in the City alone. A parish is jointly administered by a Baron and a Council of Aldermen. Some wealthy and influential Barons have several parishes under their control. It is this very situation which led to the rise of the Council of Aldermen after the forming of the Republic in 1346; when the official authority of the Saintly Faiths ended, the larger baronies required a political unit to fill this vacuum. In practice, the clergy of each parish contribute many (all in some parishes) of the Aldermen to the Council. The parish church is responsible for most of the civic duties, including collecting taxes for the Baron, allocating poor relief, conducting the Parish Bench (an ecclesiastic court which still tries most crimes, even those usually under secular authority), and organizing community events. Again, I have found that the Saintly Faith, though markedly different in this country, still maintains a large amount of control over what happens in the day-to-day lives of the people of Waldheim.

The court system is quite complicated. There are four court divisions; Ecclesiastic Court, Royal Regimental Court, Republic Law Court, and the Court of the Gentry. Their areas of jurisdiction can and do overlap frequently, causing no end of 'jurisdiction hearings', which slow down the legal process dramatically.

The Ecclesiastic court is divided into three levels. From top to bottom they are the Court of the Blue Palace (in the City), the Diocese Bench (in each County), and the Parish Bench (in each Parish). Most crimes in the counties are tried by the Parish Bench. Appeals to the Diocese Bench are possible. Crimes of the clergy at the parish level are tried at the Diocese Bench, and crimes of the clergy at the county level are tried at the Blue Palace. The ecclesiastic courts have laws which often favour the accused, and so it is common for criminals to 'claim the cloth', pretending to be clergy of any Saintly Faith, and then undergoing ecclesiastic trial.

Royal Regimental Court is a military court, which I am not familiar enough with to provide a report. This court sees very little activity, especially in these times of peace. There is one exception to this however; the Regimental Court known as 'The Fleet' in the City is a confusing institution of unparalleled corruption and iniquity. A report on the doings of this institution would be lengthy and sordid. Earls usually sit as judges in these courts.

Republic Law Court is the new law institution, implemented shortly after 1346. There are 2 divisions of this court; Common Law and Equity.

The Common Law division has 4 levels. From top-to-bottom they are;

- The Senate Bench
- The Court of Common Council
- County Court
- Justices of the Peace.

Justices of the Peace are the judges that administer most Republic Common Law. In large parishes they have their own buildings and sit often, though some counties have but a single Justice who travels from parish to parish, setting up an impromptu court to hear cases. Many prisoners in these counties wait a very long time before their case is heard.

Cases at the Justice level can be appealed to the County Court. This court also presides over inter-parish conflicts, and crimes of Aldermen and other significant trials. County Court has an urban counterpart; in the City this court is called the Ward Court. Both of these courts are presided over by Magistrates, who are ideally Justices with years of experience and a reputation for astute jurisprudence, but not always.

The Court of Common Council is presided over by Magistrates appointed by the Common Council. This court hears appeals from the County and Ward Courts, and also presides over cases involving county officials, aldermen, and other important figures. Cases in the Court of Common Council are followed very closely by the litigious people of the City, who love to debate the rulings and discuss the implications of new Case Law.

The Senate Bench is a court which sits very infrequently. It is presided over by a panel of Senators who are chosen for each case. This court hears appeals from the Court of Common Council (though these are few and controversial), and presides over matters involving Senators or the Lord Mayor of the City. These proceedings are carried out behind closed doors, though their rulings are difficult to keep secret.

The Equity Law division is a little baffling. It is a confusing mixture of pre-Republic laws and new laws, which has jurisdiction over all civil and property hearings. These cases are not presided over by Justices. The lowest level of this court is akin to the County Court, but special magistrates hold quarterly sessions in each county and ward to hear Equity Law cases. These cases are becoming more common, especially in the City, where people often take legal action against other people, not only for personal gain, but as a form of obscenely expensive entertainment and social maneuvering. Equity Law cases can be appealed to the Court of Common Council, and often are. Presently, the Court of Common Council is petitioning the Senate to open a new courthouse for the many appeals which they have to deal with, and is also asking for permission to appoint more Equity Magistrates.

The Court of the Gentry is the oldest court in the land. It has been in almost-continuous authority since the early third century AC. This court has jurisdiction over all matters of title and peerage, and is often able to assert its jurisdiction into areas it doesn't belong to protect influential nobles. This court has two levels; the House of Lords and the King's Bench. The House of Lords now sits beside Bellwether Hall in the City. It is actually a very busy court, as it hears all of the co-opted cases from other jurisdictions, as well as hearing dozens of title-claim cases every week. The proceedings in this court are also closed, and though they are supposed to be matters of privacy and dignity for the gentry, they are always leaked to the public.

The King's Bench is located in Stonesaddle, Castleshire. I am not at all privileged enough to know anything about this court, except that it is presided over by the King.

3. Nobility of the Republic

The nobility of the Republic is unlike that which we are familiar with in our country or any of the peerage-systems south of the Imperial Septum. It is markedly more simple, with but

When I began my investigation of the nobility of Waldheim, I was shocked to learn that many of the noble families trace their roots back to Abaddon, with some claiming ancestry from the Prime Pantheon. Though this smells of heresy and ancestor worship, they do not publicly claim any Grace from these blood-lines, and thus it is not strictly interdict. The oldest families, known as the 'Old Blood', have some unwritten and secret authority over younger families which it is impossible to discover unless one is noble themselves. Rumour and speculation amongst the educated burgesses of the City has it that there is a political struggle among the nobles which is currently quite embroiled; a group is emerging which is being called 'Middle Blood', which is composed of families which trace their roots to Saints and other significant historical figures between the age of Abaddon and the emergence of the Republic. The youngest of the families are known as Post-Cardigans; those families which have been granted Royal Patent since 1346.

Cryptic matters of intranobility politics aside, the framework of the nobility is quite a simple matter, compared to the systems of peerage we are familiar with south of the Imperial Septum. There are but 5 ranks of nobles, plus two ranks of acknowledgment.

The 5 ranks of nobility from top-to-bottom;

- King
- Duke
- Count
- Earl
- Baron

The present King is Goering Severinius. Goering is the patriarch of the Severinius family, and is as firm a picture of Old Blood as one would expect in a king. He is 61 years old, and is the picture of health and vitality. He spends most of his time in the City, though his throne is technically in Stonesaddle. Though he is difficult to approach on account of his retinue and guards, the man is only somewhat aloof in his dealings with people, and he does keep appointments with people outside the gentry.

The title of King is not merely an honorary one, as it is in other Republics. Goering holds real power through his absolute authority over matters of title and peerage. He has the power to appoint and withdraw noble status, which has enormous consequences, as these positions are all associated with land and the income that land provides. The king also has authority over the Royal Charters, which are the documents which give the Livery Companies their powers in the City. Though Royal Charters are not often granted (the last was in 1725) or taken away (the Royal Company of Legalists lost its charter in 1741), the Companies are acutely aware that the King controls their fate.

The King has one major limitation on his authority; he is not permitted to sit in the Senate as either a Senator or Consul. However, most kings, Goering included, have been enthroned after their term as Proconsul. This would indicate that the appointing of the King is based largely on genuine political skill.

The King is appointed in Bellwether hall. The process by which a King is appointed is largely and roundly guessed at by most people of the Republic, but those few nobles who know how the King is chosen have not given up their secret.

It is likely that the Dukes appoint the King, if most of the speculation is to be believed. Dukes themselves are known only to the nobility of the rank of Count. There are supposedly five Dukes representing the five original duchies of Abaddon, which were established by Abaddon himself. However, only a select group of Counts know who these Dukes are. It is suspected that they are publicly known as the Counts of the Old Blood families, but some of the more imaginative conspiracists of the City speculate that they are secret fiends who lay hidden from the light of day. Who ever these Dukes are, they hold the population, the gentry included, in fear and confusion; there are many stories of Counts going missing or falling upon tragedy after misspeaking himself in front of an unsuspected Duke. Dukes have become part of the Republic's popular culture as boogey-man type figures, but they do exist and have some unknown power over the nobility which I am unable to account for. Certainly, though, one is forced to think of the Masked Lords of 1346 who founded the Republic and changed Avilund forever.

Counts are the high-ranking noble which most people might have some contact with. There are 21 Counts; one for each of the 21 Counties, and they are often referred to by the title 'Lord', with their County following (eg; Lord Falconer). To add some confusion, some noble families have the same last name as their county, while others do not. Counts are all very powerful men who control vast landholdings. Most also sit in the Senate. The title of Count can be assumed by the son of a Count when he dies or relinquishes his patronage. A Count must otherwise be appointed by the King.

Earls are an interesting rank of gentry. This rank harkens back to the violent years surrounding Conquest. An Earl was traditionally a Baron who served with distinction on the battlefield. Today, Earls are still associated with the military; they are in charge of organizing the Royal Regiments, but few of them have actually seen hard battle. As in the days of yore, Earls are members of the court of the Count, acting as advisor and aid in times of peace, and defender in others. The rank of Earl is awarded by the Count, and is the only rank that is not hereditary. The son of an Earl will become a Baron when his father relinquishes his title.

Barons are wealthy land owners, and are the basic unit of organization for the peerage system. Barons are charged with the effective management of the plots of land they control; this is typically a parish, or several parishes. The title of Baron can be bestowed by the Count, in a public ceremony in the House of Lords. It is possible for a knight or esquire to become a Baron, thus granting access to the nobility for wealthy burgesses and accomplished individuals, though this climb through the social strata often takes multiple generations. This is the easiest title to lose as well; Barons who do not manage their lands effectively are often stripped of their title. If the Baron runs his affairs so poorly that he loses his land, the title is stripped automatically.

All members of these ranks are referred to as 'Lord' by those beneath them, but amongst peers, it is common to call them by their polity name.

The 2 ranks of acknowledgment are;

- Knight
- Esquire

It is possible for laymen to enter into the nobility through either of these two ranks of acknowledgment. These two ranks are markedly different.

The title of Knight has long been associated with the fighting men that accompany a Baron, Earl or Count. These are parish men who own their plot of land, large or small. In the modern age, Knights are usually the sons of Knights, and the title has remained hereditary, though it is easily stripped. It is the primary role of the Knights to organize defense and train soldiers in times of war. In times of peace they go about their own business; running a farm, pursuing a professional career, and so on. There are thousands of men in the Republic with this rank. The rank of Knight can be appointed by a Count or the King. In the modern era, many men are awarded this rank for their outstanding achievements in professional matters, such as banking, scholarship, politics or business.

The title of Esquire is also a hold-over from the distant past; Esquires used to be the favoured soldier-trainees of a Knight, who could take the rank of Knight when their master died. However, this practice has not been in use for centuries, mostly eliminated by the Knights of the past who were fearful of prematurely surrendering their life and rank to ambitious squires. Today, the title of Esquire is quite a sticky thing; a man can call himself Esquire, if he looks and acts like one; he must attend the right parties,

dressed in the right clothes, with the requisite number of servants and retinue, and display culture and learning, and so on. There is no formal acknowledgment in the House of Lords of this title. The title is in no way hereditary, nor does it command any other benefit than the respect (or more likely, the contempt) of lesser men, and the chance for recognition by the nobility and possibly a barony. There are thousands of men who go by this title (and some ambitious and unconventional *women*), especially since the creation of the New Finance. These men are bankers and traders, with great wealth. Indeed, many men who go by this title are wealthier than the barons and counts whom they prostrate themselves before. Any man going by this title has aspirations towards the nobility, but very, very few ever achieve this.

Men of both ranks of acknowledgment are addressed as ‘Sir’.

The nobility of the Republic are a more xenophobic group than the nobles of the South. They tend not to marry into the nobility of their surrounding neighbours, let alone more distant countries, which is the custom in our land. However, some of the Old Blood families have traditional ties with some of our most influential families, though it is difficult to ascertain the extent of these connections, or if indeed they are anything more than historical quirks of some families.

It is important to note that in the ranks of peerage, it is unacceptable for a noble to be involved directly in trade or any other business. They may own business, and have men and women who see to their functioning, but they do not get dirt under their fingernails. This also extends to matters of the New Finance; they are not permitted to buy and sell ‘commodities’ and ‘futures’ (whatever these intangible and vexing fiscal fairies may be) with the stock jobbers. However, many send their wives and servants to do just that, as it is lucrative business just now.

It is easy to rub shoulders with the nobility in the Republic, because of the overly important nature of the City. They all come to the City eventually, and most have town houses or villas in which they spend part of the year. Some enterprising Esquires have *developed* areas of the City for the habitation of the Nobility, as more and more of them seek accommodations there; they have built exquisite town houses which they lease to nobles (or anyone who can afford it). These areas are associated with the growing numbers of fine parks and refined spaces in the city which are popping up in many places.

4. The Workings of the City of Waldheim

I could write a hundred pages about the small goings-on of the City; the bustling trade that goes on, the hectic markets, the interesting brands of crime, the strangeness of the courtship rituals, the odd food they eat, and many hundreds of other things. However, I must limit myself to the salient elements of the workings of the City that pertain to your expected and much-anticipated visit herein.

A. Political Structure of the City

The City *is* the Republic. Or at least it was. When the Order of Bellwether put an end to ecclesiastic rule of the City in 1346, the Republic they set up had her borders no more than a few miles from the nexus of the Wen and Nith. However, the success of the Republic can be measured by how far it has spread; today, her borders are fixed, as they butted up against their likewise-expanding neighbours during the 16th and 17th centuries. While swallowing up all the duchies, counties and other polities that surrounded her, the City always remained the heart of the Republic. The City has always had all the civic buildings required for the function of the State, as well as all the ecclesiastic buildings and institutions needed for the Saintly maintenance of a peaceable civilization. The City is located at the nexus of the two great Imperial Rivers; this site is exactly why the Elders chose it, one would imagine. This City sits atop the ruins of the macrocephalous capitals of several erstwhile cultures and races. In the time of Men, however, it has known its greatest wonders and largest populations.

The City fits into the Republic a little differently than the counties. The City is its own polity, with no nobility associated to the land of the City. This was a specific design of Bellwether, who established in their earliest ordnances following their separation from the Empire, that no family would ever hold landed-titles from the City (though most own much property in the City itself). This has kept a successful balance of power in the families for centuries.

The City is subject to the laws of the Republic, but it also governs its own municipal matters. The head of the City is the Lord Mayor. Every two years, nominations for Lord Mayor are submitted by the Livery Companies. There are usually 8-16 nominees, and these men are all drawn from the Parliament (members of the Common Council, also known as the House of Commons), the Senate, or the City Council of Aldermen. Most are Aldermen, and most are lesser nobility, Knights or Esquires.

The current Lord Mayor is Sir Jeremy Rowan of Newton Hill. Sir Jeremy is serving the first year of his second term in this office (he held the office from 1743-5). He is a wealthy man who is a faithful follower of Ulric, but a close supporter of Severinius and Sebald in the City. He is the Alderman for his Ward, Newton Hill, which is an achievement in itself; there are many men capable of this office from that Ward, and the competition for the office would have been tremendous. The Lord Mayor has been instrumental in the flourishing of the Bank of Waldheim, and is a supporter of the New Finance, though it is no secret that he holds aspirations for Title. As would befit such a man, he is surrounded by an enormous retinue, and need never sully his hands or his reputation by dealing directly with the stock-jobbers and other venture-seekers.

Sir Jeremy holds some animosity for the Senate; it is well known that he has resisted Senatorial attempts to divert funding from the City to pay for the diversions of nobles outside of the City. He has even opposed increases in taxes to support some of the standing Royal Regiments, especially those distant from the City. This Lord Mayor is a man born and bred of the City, and his interests do not go far beyond his walls, even when the Senate insists otherwise. Rowan has made his way to his current position through savvy relations with the Royal Companies (Livery Companies, or Trade Guilds).

That is no surprise, I suppose; any Lord Mayor needs the support of at least one Royal Company to even become a nominee for the chair. However, Rowan has very close ties to the Royal Companies of Haberdashers, Goldsmiths, Glovers and Clockmakers, which are very influential Companies. He has repaid their patronage by endorsing and encouraging the consumption of fashionable clothing and related goods in the City, if any encouraging was needed; the moneyed people of the City go about in the newest and finest clothes they can afford. Though he is not popular in the Senate, he has long been respected in the City Council of Aldermen, and he has a fair reputation among the ecclesiastic authorities as well; the Bishop of St. Ulric is a close friend, and he is on excellent terms with the Bishops of St. Sever and St. Sebald. He has turned down the office of Arch Bishop of St. Cardigan more than once, though this has not harmed his relations with this faith.

B. Political Division of the City and it's Workings

At the head of the City is the Lord Mayor. He is responsible for most of the law-making and policy-making of the City, and her relations with the Senate, the House of Lords, and the Common Council.

Beneath the Lord Mayor is the City Council of Aldermen (or 'City Council'). This is a council of 18 Aldermen who each represent the 18 Wards of the City. Aldermen are elected for life in their Ward, and serve on this Council more or less full-time, though some have other professional pursuits. The City Council is responsible, along with the Lord Mayor, for law- and policy-making, but they are also responsible for the implementing of these measures. They are also responsible for the organization of the seven Royal Regiments of the City.

The next level of organization in the City is the Ward. There are 18 of them now, and will likely be more as the City continues to grow in both size and population. Each Ward is further subdivided into Parishes, and there are presently 95 parishes in the City. The Ward is governed by the Ward Council, which is made up of the Councilors from each Parish; some Wards may have as few as 3 parishes, others as many as 8. The Ward Council has an Alderman chosen from the Councilors, and he serves for life. This is the man who sits in the City Council of Aldermen. These men are all, without exception, powerful, wealthy, influential men. Some of them have significant noble titles (there is one Count on the Council), many are influential freemen of the Royal Companies, and a few are non-secular authorities; Bishop Madison (St. Severinius) is the Alderman for Imperial Terrace Parish in Elderton Ward.

The Wards are responsible for maintaining the Ward Court (the second highest court in the City; appeals go to the Court of Common Council, just as appeals from County Courts), and the appointment of a Magistrate, who is the highest Judge in the Ward. The Ward court hears appeals from the Parish Justices (lower judges) and presides over all cases of condemnable offenses. The Ward maintains a Ward Jail (some are small, one room affairs, but others are enormous, brooding dungeons and towers.) It also maintains a small Ward Garrison, which is a kind of local police force that assists the Parish

Constables when they are in over their heads. The Wards receive a third-penny from the Parish taxes, much of which seems to end up in the pockets of the Councilors.

The parishes of the City are where the real business of day-to-day administration of the City occurs. The parishes are ecclesiastic holdouts from before 1348, when this business was governed by the Faith, and by the parish priest in particular. Today, in the City, it is a bit more complicated than that.

The parishes are governed by the Parish Council, which has any number of Councilors appointed or elected. Some of the larger parishes have dozens of councilors, while others have just a few. Each parish has a leading councilor, and they have many different titles which seem to be local peculiarities; Reeve is a common title, but others include secretary, warden, commissioner, elder, and so on. Many parishes have an ecclesiastic official as the Head of Council. Of course, as mentioned, the Heads of Council sit in the Ward Council, and one of those is chosen as Alderman for the Ward, who sits on the City Council of Aldermen. Most councilors are called ‘alderman’ by the common people as a term of respect, though this term specifically refers to the 18 men mentioned above.

The parish is responsible for appointing one Justice, the judge who hears cases from his parish. Some of these justices hear cases in their own homes, but most successful parishes have their own court, or common building which includes court facilities. Some parishes have small jails, but most send prisoners to the Ward Jail. Each parish is responsible for the maintenance of its streets, sewers, lights, and other common buildings and facilities. It collects taxes in any number of ways and in any share it sees fit. Some parishes have heavy taxes, and others light. These taxes usually, though not always, correspond to the overall quality of the parish.

The parish is also responsible for poor relief, which has made for a very interesting brand of bureaucracy and crime all at once. The parishes pay poor relief as they see fit, and this relief varies from a few shillings per week in some of the poorest parishes, to as much as 20s per week in the most charitable. As such, the City has long conducted extensive, accurate censuses in each parish, and citizens are not permitted to move to another parish unless they can prove they have gainful employment. Of course, the cunning poor of the City always seek out ways to make themselves citizens of the more charitable parishes, which leads to brands of crime that we have never encountered in our country; I once witnessed a group of men carrying a poor woman, in her throes of birthing, over parish lines so that her bastard child would be born in and paid for by the neighbouring parish. The census is, however, truly a marvel of the City. It is carried out at the parish level, though the Wards can audit their parishes when they see fit, and the City can likewise audit the Wards. Census documentation is, for the most part, very impressive.

C. Commerce and Trade in the City

Trade in Waldheim happens on a scale that we have not seen since before the 4th Crusade. The historic image of the busy bazaars of Lysander and other southern cities is alive and well in Waldheim, and it seems still to be growing. The City does not have the benefit

that long-distance trade seems to have on an Economy, but you wouldn't know it. The Republic is doing excellent trade with other partners along the river valleys, though very little outside these two valleys. Wine comes from St. Ignatius, raw resources flow in from the distant north, and so forth. The City refines all these things and puts them up in their busy markets. There have been talks of securing the Via Lysander for years, but the ambitious Venture Companies of the City seem veritably poised to make a mentionable effort to do just that. When this happens, we can expect to see Northerners in every City south of the Imperial Septum, but with most of the profits migrating to Waldheim. The Republic (and some of her neighbours) is centuries ahead of us in terms of the flow of goods and money, and we stand to lose substantial amounts of money if we are unable to catch them up.

For centuries, the heart of the economic system in Waldheim has been her Livery Companies (or Royal Companies). These are akin to our guilds, but they are more peaceable and regulated. The Companies each represent an aspect of labour, service or commerce, and they are allowed to make their own rules and regulations about that trade. They are given a Royal Charter from the King. This is an interesting holdout from earlier times; The King has granted Royal Charters since the 1000's, and continues to do so. This has kept a considerable amount of power in the hands of the King.

In the last 15 years, the Republic has been developing what is called the 'New Finance'. This term refers to a number of endeavours, which I will discuss with as much expertise as I have, though I confess that I do not understand every nuance of this business.

For starters, the Republic uses a number of paper currencies. Though even in our own lands we have long used notes of debt and promise, the Republic prints notes that are as exchangeable as a coin. These are mostly printed by the new-found Bank of Waldheim, which Consul Spinner is heavily involved in. The notes are guaranteed by the bank, and they come in denominations as high as 1000s. The Bank is now also a major lending power, to the dismay and financial hardship of many nobles and other money lenders. The Bank is able to offer very good terms, and it is regulated enough that debtors know that they will not repay with their flesh and bones.

There are other paper currencies that circulate as well; many large companies, and now, even some of the Royal Companies, print their own money, though these are not as commonly accepted as the Bank notes, and there are many problems with these money-printers. The Bank seems poised to soon control a monopoly on printed money, which will benefit the Republic's public coffers tremendously, and many of her investors.

Investment and Stock is the crux of the New Finance. Companies sell 'Stock' in their business in order to grow it; they might build a new work house, patent a new invention, send big river-boats on mercantile enterprises and so on. The Stock is not guaranteed, but any profit that the company makes returns as a payment to the Stock holder. Stocks are potentially limitless; companies will sell as many as they can, and the very selling of these imaginary commodities has become an industry unto itself. Though many unwary investors lose everything (there are countless varieties of misadventure for the investor),

so many are making such good money at it, that Investment and Stocks are sure to flourish for a long time yet. One of the most significant consequences of this aspect of the New Finance is that a great deal of capital is being poured into business, which provides the Economy of the Republic with an alacrity which we have not seen for hundreds of years. Even the nobility is partaking in this speculation, which has the effect of drawing huge amounts of capital that would have otherwise sat idle, and which stimulates the economy even more. There are a few bankrupt nobles to account for, but there are a good many richer, and many more Companies besides.

As mentioned above, one of the central figures in the New Finance is Consul Spinner. I have learned that he is personally financing the building of 3 great ocean-going vessels, the likes of which have not been built by Men of the Empire in many centuries. The Consul will send these boats abroad in the next couple of years, and they are bound to have the best weapons, navigation tools, and other equipment that the innovative and industrious people of the City are able to produce. It seems likely that these ships may again open the waters for Men, and I find it remarkable though shameful that it is the New Finance, and not the Faith, that will launch this endeavour.